

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mr Ash Garg

Address: 19 Riverside Close Wallington SM6 7DH

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer objects to the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I object to the proposed planning application on the following grounds:

The National Planning Policy Framework (December 2024) requires developments to promote social interaction and healthy communities, and to ensure they do not undermine community cohesion (paras 96 and related). This should be considered. This proposal risks the opposite.

The borough needs neutral, multi-use community spaces (e.g. halls, youth centres, recreational venues) that serve residents of all backgrounds and faiths equally, rather than a specialised facility for one group. Prioritising shared infrastructure would better foster genuine unity.

The borough already has multiple functional/operational mosques in operation.

This appears significantly disproportionate relative to the local Muslim population (based on census/demographic data).

At the same time, other faith groups - with similar proportion of population - have no dedicated place of worship at all.

Further provision for one group raises serious concerns about fairness, equitable resource allocation, and balanced treatment of all faith communities.

A fact-finding exercise should be done to check proportion of local population of different faiths and how many places of worship already exist before approving any new ones.

UK policy has moved away from failed multiculturalism towards active integration and assimilation. The Casey Review (2016) warned of "parallel lives," residential clustering, and segregation risks in some communities.

Additional large or concentrated faith facilities frequently become focal points that encourage clustering, leading within a few years to enclaves with:

- reduced everyday mixing between groups
- diminished shared British identity
- the very ghettoisation the Review cautioned against.

An example is in nearby Morden where a big mosque has seen local demography change in last decade.

In our beautiful borough, already experiencing demographic pressures and change, approving another mosque is likely to entrench separation rather than build inclusive cohesion - directly contrary to NPPF goals for unified, integrated places.